

أَعُوذُ بِاللَّهِ مِنَ الشَّيْطَانِ الرَّجِيمِ

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Lisan ul Quran — Lecture 17

Jumla Ismiyyah · Asma' ul Isharah as Muftada

1. Introduction to the Asma' ul Isharah

The *Asma' ul Isharah* are words by which one points to some person, thing or place. The pointing may be to something near at hand or to something far off. Urdu generally uses "this" and "that", but in Arabic the words of pointing change according to gender and number.

The thing pointed to is called the *Mushar Ilayh*. It is required that the *Mushar Ilayh* be visible and perceptible; if the pointing is to something imperceptible, the usage is figurative.

The four aspects of an Ism ul Isharah

As with any noun in Arabic, an *Ism ul Isharah* too is viewed from four aspects.

Aspect	Details
Wus'at	All Asma' ul Isharah are Ma'rifah
Jins	There are separate words for the Mudhakkar and the Mu'annath
'Adad	There are separate words for the Wahid, the Tathniyah and the Jam'
I'raab	In a sentence they are generally Marfoo', that is, they occupy the place of the Muftada

2. The complete table of the Asma' ul Isharah

The *Asma' ul Isharah* divide into two broad categories: those for what is near and those for what is far.

- All the *Asma' ul Isharah* for what is near begin with the letter هـ.
- All those for what is far end with a ك.
- For the *Jam'* there is one and the same word for masculine and feminine, which is why there are five words for the near and five for the far.

Jins	Wahid	Tathniyah — raf	Tathniyah — nasb & jarr	Jam'
Asma' ul Isharah for what is near				

Jins	Wahid	Tathniyah — raf'	Tathniyah — nasb & jarr	Jam'
Mudhakkar	هَذَا	هَذَانِ	هَذَيْنِ	هَؤُلَاءِ
Mu'annath	هَذِهِ	هَاتَانِ	هَاتَيْنِ	هَؤُلَاءِ
Asma' ul Isharah for what is far				
Mudhakkar	ذَلِكَ	ذُنَيْكَ	ذُنَيْنِكَ	أُولَئِكَ
Mu'annath	تِلْكَ	تَانِكَ	تَيْنِكَ	أُولَئِكَ

The Haa' ut Tanbeeh and the three degrees of pointing

The "ha" that comes at the beginning of the near *Asma' ul Isharah* is called the **Haa' ut Tanbeeh**.

Without it the base forms are ذَا and تَا, and with the "ha" attached they become هَذَا and هَآذَا.

The rule of recognition: If an *Ism ul Isharah* is free of both a lam and a kaf, it is for what is near, as in هَذَا ، هَذَانِ. If a kaf alone comes at its end, it is for the middle distance, as in ذَاكَ ، ذَاكُمَا. And if both a lam and a kaf come at its end, it is for what is far, as in ذَلِكَ ، ذَلِكَُمَا.

Pointing to a place

- هُنَا ، هُنَا — here, pointing to a near place
- هُنَاكَ — there, pointing to a place at middle distance
- هُنَالِكَ — there, pointing to a distant place

3. The Ism ul Isharah as Mubtada

Rule: When a *Nakirah* noun comes immediately after an *Ism ul Isharah*, the two together form a complete *Jumla Ismiyyah*. The *Ism ul Isharah* becomes the *Mubtada* and the *Nakirah* noun the *Khabar*. In such a case **the Khabar is free of alif lam**. Both are *Marfoo'*, and they match each other in gender and number.

وَهَذَا كِتَابٌ أَنْزَلْنَاهُ مُبَارَكٌ فَاتَّبِعُوهُ وَاتَّقُوا لَعَلَّكُمْ تُرْحَمُونَ

(Surah al-An'am: 155)

Translation: And this is a Book which We have sent down, blessed; so follow it and be mindful of Allah, that you may be shown mercy.

- هَذَا is the *Ism ul Isharah* and is *Ma'rifah*; this is the *Mubtada*.
- كِتَابٌ is a *Nakirah* noun; this is the *Khabar*.

4. Tables of examples

The tables below give all four cases — near masculine, near feminine, far masculine and far feminine — with the singular, dual and plural.

With the word Muslim

Case	Wahid	Tathniyah	Jam'
near Mudhakkar	هَذَا مُسْلِمٌ	هَذَانِ مُسْلِمَانِ	هَؤُلَاءِ مُسْلِمُونَ
near Mu'annath	هَذِهِ مُسْلِمَةٌ	هَاتَانِ مُسْلِمَتَانِ	هَؤُلَاءِ مُسْلِمَاتٌ
far Mudhakkar	ذَلِكَ مُسْلِمٌ	ذُنْكَ مُسْلِمَانِ	أُولَئِكَ مُسْلِمُونَ
far Mu'annath	تِلْكَ مُسْلِمَةٌ	تَانِكَ مُسْلِمَتَانِ	أُولَئِكَ مُسْلِمَاتٌ

With the word Talib

Case	Wahid	Tathniyah	Jam'
near Mudhakkar	هَذَا طَالِبٌ	هَذَانِ طَالِبَانِ	هَؤُلَاءِ طَالِبُونَ
near Mu'annath	هَذِهِ طَالِبَةٌ	هَاتَانِ طَالِبَتَانِ	هَؤُلَاءِ طَالِبَاتٌ
far Mudhakkar	ذَلِكَ طَالِبٌ	ذُنْكَ طَالِبَانِ	أُولَئِكَ طَالِبُونَ
far Mu'annath	تِلْكَ طَالِبَةٌ	تَانِكَ طَالِبَتَانِ	أُولَئِكَ طَالِبَاتٌ

With the word Salih

Case	Wahid	Tathniyah	Jam'
near Mudhakkar	هَذَا صَالِحٌ	هَذَانِ صَالِحَانِ	هَؤُلَاءِ صَالِحُونَ
near Mu'annath	هَذِهِ صَالِحَةٌ	هَاتَانِ صَالِحَتَانِ	هَؤُلَاءِ صَالِحَاتٌ
far Mudhakkar	ذَلِكَ صَالِحٌ	ذُنْكَ صَالِحَانِ	أُولَئِكَ صَالِحُونَ
far Mu'annath	تِلْكَ صَالِحَةٌ	تَانِكَ صَالِحَتَانِ	أُولَئِكَ صَالِحَاتٌ

With Rajul and Imra'ah

Case	Wahid	Tathniyah	Jam'
near Mudhakkar	هَذَا رَجُلٌ	هَذَانِ رَجُلَانِ	هَؤُلَاءِ رِجَالٌ
near Mu'annath	هَذِهِ امْرَأَةٌ	هَئَاتَانِ امْرَأَتَانِ	هَؤُلَاءِ نِسَاءٌ
far Mudhakkar	ذَلِكَ رَجُلٌ	ذُنْكَ رَجُلَانِ	أُولَئِكَ رِجَالٌ
far Mu'annath	تِلْكَ امْرَأَةٌ	تَانِكَ امْرَأَتَانِ	أُولَئِكَ نِسَاءٌ

Worth noting: In the last table the *Khabars* are *Jam' Mukassar*. The plural of رَجُلٌ is رِجَالٌ and that of امْرَأَةٌ is نِسَاءٌ, and neither is a *Jam' Salim*. Since these are plurals of the '*Aqil*, the pointing word too has come in the plural.

5. 'Aqil and Ghayr 'Aqil

In Arabic grammar all creation is divided into two categories. Only three kinds fall under the '*Aqil*: human beings, angels and jinn. All the rest are counted *Ghayr 'Aqil*.

When using an *Ism ul Isharah* for a *Ghayr 'Aqil* noun, its being masculine or feminine is kept in view, and the pointing word follows that agreement.

- هَذَا كُرْسِيٌّ — this is a chair. The word كُرْسِيٌّ is masculine in Arabic, which is why هَذَا has come.
- هَذِهِ سَاعَةٌ — this is a watch.
- هَذِهِ حَقِيبَةٌ — this is a bag.

6. A most important note: the plural of the Ghayr 'Aqil

The governing principle: The Arabs use the **singular feminine** for a plural of the *Ghayr 'Aqil*. This principle applies to the *Khabar* and to the *Ism ul Isharah* alike.

6.1 The ruling on the Khabar

When the *Mubtada* of a *Jumla Ismiyyah* is a *Jam' Mukassar* of the *Ghayr 'Aqil*, its *Khabar* generally comes as singular feminine.

- الْكُرَاسِيُّ مَكْسُورَةٌ — the chairs are broken.
- الْأَبْوَابُ مَفْتُوحَةٌ — the doors are open.

- أَلَسَّاعَاتُ كَبِيرَةٌ — the watches are large.

6.2 The ruling on the Ism ul Isharah

Likewise, when the *Khabar* of a *Jumla Ismiyyah* is a *Jam' Mukassar* of the *Ghayr 'Aqil*, the *Ism ul Isharah* for it will also come as singular feminine.

- هَذِهِ كُرَاسِيٌّ , تِلْكَ كُرَاسِيٌّ — these, or those, are chairs.
- هَذِهِ مَدَارِسُ — these are schools.
- هَذِهِ أَقْلَامٌ — these are pens.

Case	Wahid	Tathniyah	Jam'
near Mudhakkar	هَذَا قَلَمٌ	هَذَانِ قَلَمَانِ	هَذِهِ أَقْلَامٌ
near Mu'annath	هَذِهِ كُرْسِيَّةٌ	هَاتَانِ كُرْسِيَّتَانِ	هَذِهِ كُرْسِيَّاتٌ
far Mudhakkar	ذَلِكَ بَابٌ	ذُنُكْ بَابَانِ	تِلْكَ أَبْوَابٌ
far Mu'annath	تِلْكَ سَاعَةٌ	تَانِكَ سَاعَتَانِ	تِلْكَ سَاعَاتٌ

Look closely at the plural column. In all four cases the pointing word has come as **singular feminine** — هَذِهِ for the near and تِلْكَ for the far — whether the *Mushar Ilayh* is masculine or feminine.

Where else this principle operates: For a plural of the *Ghayr 'Aqil* it is not only the *Khabar* and the *Ism ul Isharah* but also the *Ism ud Dameer*, the *Ism ul Mawsul*, the *Ism us Sifah* and the *Fi'l* that come as singular feminine. This is why feminine forms appear in the Qur'an at such places.

7. Why does Surah al-Baqarah say Dhalika al-Kitab?

هَذَا is used for a thing or person that is near, whereas ذَلِكَ is used for one that is far. Generally, if something is present before us we use هَذَا for it, and if it is at a distance we use ذَلِكَ.

ذَلِكَ الْكِتَابُ لَا رَيْبَ فِيهِ

(Surah al-Baqarah: 2)

Translation: This is the Book about which there is no doubt.

Outwardly the Qur'an is present with us, so it would seem that هَذَا الْكِتَابُ should have come; yet the Qur'an says ذَلِكَ الْكِتَابُ. The reason for this is a most subtle rhetorical usage of the Arabic language.

The two kinds of distance

In Arabic, distance is not only of place but also of rank.

Kind	Meaning
Bu'd Makani	Being far in respect of place and distance. For a thing at a distance from a person, an <i>Ism ul Isharah</i> for what is far is used.
Bu'd Rutbi	A thing being elevated in respect of rank, greatness, honour and station. In such a case, even though the thing is present nearby, an <i>Ism ul Isharah</i> for what is far may still be used to convey its lofty station.

The rhetoric of Dhalika al-Kitab: In respect of place the Qur'an is near to a person, for it can be read, held in the hand and seen. But in respect of rank, greatness and honour it holds the most elevated station. It is to convey that very greatness that ذَٰلِكَ has been used. This is a beautiful specimen of the eloquence of Arabic: that for a thing of greatness the form of the far is brought.

Why is it translated "this Book"?

Urdu and English do not have this usage of *bu'd rutbi*. For that reason, in translating, "this Book" is said rather than "that Book", so that the sense stays clear. Some translators have rendered it "this is that Book" in order to bring out the rhetorical point, but the plain and common rendering is simply "this is the Book".

8. The singular feminine Isharah in Tilka ar-Rusul

تِلْكَ الرُّسُلُ فَضَّلْنَا بَعْضَهُمْ عَلَى بَعْضٍ

(Surah al-Baqarah: 253)

Translation: These are the messengers; some of them We favoured above others.

Here الرُّسُلُ is a plural of the *'Aqil*, yet تِلْكَ has been used for it, which is the singular feminine pointing word. By the rule, أُولَٰئِكَ should have come here.

The explanation: In Arabic a plural is sometimes taken in the sense of a body or group. الرُّسُلُ here means a company of messengers, and the word جَمَاعَةٌ is singular feminine. In that respect the use of تِلْكَ is sound.

The rules of Arabic state general principles, but at certain places a usage departing from those principles is also adopted. تِلْكَ الرُّسُلُ is one such place, where a singular feminine pointing word has been used for a plural of the *'Aqil*, and it is counted as a usage excepted from the rule.

9. The Kaf ul Khitab

The kaf that comes at the end of the far *Asma' ul Isharah* is called the **Kaf ul Khitab**.

An important principle: This kaf comes according to the person or persons **being spoken to**. A change in the thing or person being pointed at does not necessarily change the kaf; the kaf belongs to the *Mukhatab*, the one addressed.

The one addressed	Form of the kaf	Mudhakkar	Mu'annath
one person	كَ	ذَلِكَ	تِلْكَ
two persons	كُما	ذُلُكُما	تِلْكُما
several persons	كُم	ذُلِکُمْ	تِلْکُمْ

- ذَٰلِكَ زَيْدٌ — that is Zayd. Here Zayd is one and the one addressed is one as well.
- ذَٰلِكُمَا زَيْدٌ — that is Zayd. Here the pointing is still to a single person, but two are being addressed.
- ذَٰلِكُمْ زَيْدٌ — that is Zayd. Here too the pointing is to one person, but the listeners are several.

Examples from the Qur'an

ذَٰلِكُمْ خَيْرٌ لَّكُمْ عِنْدَ بَارِئِكُمْ

(Surah al-Baqarah: 54)

Translation: That is better for you in the sight of your Maker.

Here the kum in ذَٰلِكُمْ is for several persons addressed.

ذَٰلِكُمَا بِمَا عَلَّمَنِي رَبِّي

(Surah Yusuf: 37)

Translation: That is of what my Lord has taught me.

Here the kuma in ذَٰلِكُمَا is for two persons addressed.

وَنُودُوا أَن تِلْكَ الْجَنَّةُ الَّتِي أُورِثْتُمُوهَا بِمَا كُنْتُمْ تَعْمَلُونَ

(Surah al-A'raf: 43)

Translation: And they will be called: this is the Garden which you have been made to inherit for what you used to do.

Here the kum in تِلْکُمْ is for several persons addressed.

وَنَادَاهُمَا رَبُّهُمَا أَلَمْ أَنْهَكُمَا عَنْ تِلْكَ الشَّجَرَةِ

(Surah al-A'raf: 22)

Translation: And their Lord called out to them both: did I not forbid you two from that tree?

Here the kuma in تِلْكَ has come for two persons addressed.

10. The Asma' ul Isharah and I'raab

Rule: Among the *Asma' ul Isharah* the singular and plural forms generally stay one and the same in all three states of *raf'*, *nasb* and *jarr*. Such nouns are called **Mabni**. The dual forms, by contrast, are **Mu'rab**, so their shape changes with the *I'raab*: in the state of *raf'* the ending is "ani", and in *nasb* and *jarr* it is "ayni".

Halat ur Raf'	Halat un Nasb wal Jarr
هَذَانِ	هَذَيْنِ
هَاتَانِ	هَاتَيْنِ
ذُنُوكَ	ذَيْنِكَ
تَانِكَ	تَيْنِكَ

A practical point: The dual *Asma' ul Isharah* are used hardly at all in the Qur'an. The greatest effort in memorising should therefore go to the singular and plural forms.

Summary

1. The Asma' ul Isharah are words by which one points to a person, thing or place, and the thing pointed to is called the Mushar Ilayh.
2. All Asma' ul Isharah are Ma'rifah, and in a sentence they generally come as Marfoo', in the place of the Muftada.
3. All the near Asma' ul Isharah begin with the letter هـ and all the far ones end with a ك.
4. For the plural there is one word for both genders: هَؤُلَاءِ for the near and أُولَئِكَ for the far.
5. The "ha" at the beginning of the near forms is called the Haa' ut Tanbeeh, and without it the base forms are هَا and هُنَا.
6. An Isharah free of lam and kaf is for what is near, one with a kaf alone for the middle distance, and one with both lam and kaf for what is far.
7. For places the words are هُنَا, هُنَاكَ and هُنَاكَ.
8. When a Nakirah noun comes immediately after an Ism ul Isharah, a Jumla Ismiyyah is formed, with the Ism ul Isharah as Muftada and the Nakirah noun as Khabar.
9. In such a case the Khabar is free of alif lam, and both are Marfoo' and matched in gender and number.
10. Only three kinds of creation are 'Aqil: human beings, angels and jinn. All the rest are Ghayr 'Aqil.
11. For a singular Ghayr 'Aqil the pointing word follows its own gender, as in هَذِهِ سَاعَةٌ and هَذَا كُرْسِيٌّ.
12. The Arabs use the singular feminine for a plural of the Ghayr 'Aqil, and this applies to the Khabar and to the Ism ul Isharah alike.
13. هَذِهِ أَقْلَامٌ and الْأَبْوَابُ مَفْتُوحَةٌ are examples of this same principle.
14. For a plural of the Ghayr 'Aqil the Ism ud Dameer, Ism ul Mawsul, Ism us Sifah and Fi'l also come as singular feminine.
15. In Arabic there are two kinds of distance: Bu'd Makani, distance of place, and Bu'd Rutbi, elevation of rank.
16. In ذَٰلِكَ الْكِتَابُ the far form has come on account of Bu'd Rutbi, that is, to convey the greatness and lofty station of the Qur'an.
17. Since Urdu and English have no such usage, the rendering is given as "this is the Book".
18. In تِلْكَ الرُّسُلُ a singular feminine Isharah has come for a plural of the 'Aqil, because the plural was taken in the sense of a group, and the word جَمَاعَةٌ is singular feminine.
19. The kaf at the end of the far Asma' ul Isharah is called the Kaf ul Khitab, and it belongs not to the Mushar Ilayh but to the one addressed.
20. For one person addressed the form is كَ, for two كُمَا and for several كُمْ, as in ذَٰلِكُمْ, ذَٰلِكُمْ and ذَٰلِكُمْ.
21. The singular and plural Asma' ul Isharah are Mabni, while the dual forms are Mu'rab, taking "ani" in raf' and "ayni" in nasb and jarr.

Exercise

1. Define the Asma' ul Isharah and explain the Mushar Ilayh.
 2. Write the four aspects of an Ism ul Isharah.
 3. Set out all the near and far Asma' ul Isharah in the form of a table.
 4. What is the "ha" at the beginning of the near forms called, and what are the base forms without it?
 5. Write the rule distinguishing the near, the middle distance and the far.
 6. Write the rule by which an Ism ul Isharah becomes the Muftada, and explain it from Surah al-An'am verse 155.
 7. Form the singular, dual and plural sentences for all four cases with the word Talib.
 8. Define 'Aqil and Ghayr 'Aqil and give three examples of each.
 9. What is the ruling on the Khabar and on the Ism ul Isharah for a plural of the Ghayr 'Aqil? Give two examples of each.
 10. Which other forms come as singular feminine for a plural of the Ghayr 'Aqil?
 11. Explain the difference between Bu'd Makani and Bu'd Rutbi.
 12. Why does ذَلِكَ come rather than هَذَا at the beginning of Surah al-Baqarah? Explain in detail.
 13. Give the explanation for the singular feminine Isharah in تِلْكَ الرُّسُلُ.
 14. What is the Kaf ul Khitab, and to what does it belong?
 15. Write all three forms of the Kaf ul Khitab with both genders, and give a Qur'anic example of each.
 16. Which Asma' ul Isharah are Mabni and which are Mu'rab? Write both states of the dual.
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سُبْحَانَكَ اللَّهُمَّ وَبِحَمْدِكَ، أَشْهَدُ أَنْ لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا أَنْتَ، أَسْتَغْفِرُكَ وَأَتُوبُ إِلَيْكَ

اللَّهُمَّ صَلِّ عَلَى مُحَمَّدٍ وَعَلَى آلِ مُحَمَّدٍ كَمَا صَلَّيْتَ عَلَى إِبْرَاهِيمَ وَعَلَى آلِ إِبْرَاهِيمَ إِنَّكَ حَمِيدٌ مَجِيدٌ

اللَّهُمَّ بَارِكْ عَلَى مُحَمَّدٍ وَعَلَى آلِ مُحَمَّدٍ كَمَا بَارَكْتَ عَلَى إِبْرَاهِيمَ وَعَلَى آلِ إِبْرَاهِيمَ إِنَّكَ حَمِيدٌ مَجِيدٌ